

KF52 Meeting Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

This is our KF prayer using Nancy's Bible translation: "Examine me, O God, and discover my heart. Run experiments on me and become intimate with my fearful thoughts. See if there is any hurtful or idolatrous way in me, and lead me in the ways of eternity." (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

In this last meeting of the training cycle, we would all like to get an idea of what God is doing in the world through you. Traditionally, during the presenting time, we each briefly share what we do for a living and how we support the wider community. Feel free to pass, if you wish.

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

Everyone who wishes to continue to have access to the KF website must re-register. Completing your registration now will keep you connected to the website and remove a burden from the hard-working KF admin team. If KF admin does not receive your registration, the system will disconnect you and move you to the "inactive" list.

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Sit or stand with the crown of your head reaching toward the heavens and your tailbone reaching toward the earth. Begin with **Alternate Nostril Breathing** for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Now, allow your shoulders and arms to drop into a relaxed position. As you breathe, observe your body. Are there any areas of tension that you might allow to rest? *(Pause)* Breathe, and let your body soften on the exhale. Relax your face. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Waiting on the Lord

With your eyes closed, imagine that you are looking through your forehead and into the light. Imagine that the light is pouring into your eyes. As you inhale, you might explore pulling energy up from the earth through your tailbone, filling your spinal column. As you exhale, allow the energy to drain back into the earth. Practice for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

At some point, perhaps right now, you might imagine that you are gazing into the face of Jesus, or into the glory of God. Just silently absorb and breathe for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Continue to breathe as you listen to these verses from Psalm 36 in Nancy's translation:

⁸They drink their fill from the overflow of Your house,
 And You give them to drink from the river of Your delights.
⁹For with You is the fountain of life; in Your light we see light.
¹⁰O continue Your kindness to those who know You,
 And Your faithfulness to the oriented heart.¹

Pause, and gently open your eyes. Take a deep breath and re-engage with the meeting. *(Pause)*

Our hymn for this last confession is *Be Thou My Vision*.

High King of Heaven, my victory won;
 May I reach Heaven's joys, O bright Heaven's Sun!
 Heart of my own heart, whatever befall,
 Still be my Vision, O Ruler of all.²

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

Let's listen once again to our final KF Confession:

We circulate our true resources, reconnecting to our Creator and to the Creation.

In these last few lessons, we have introduced the idea of flow. As we circulate our true resources, we keep the flow moving.

We learned in KF30 that there are two levels of karis. At the first level, we lay the foundation of trust, which is necessary for any karis relationship. This level has three steps. By practicing these steps, you show God that you are serious about developing your relationship with Him and that you intend to learn to be trustworthy. At this first level, you train to:

1. **Obey kingdom law:** learn God's kingdom law of orientation and obey it.
2. **Cultivate more orientation:** learn what orientation feels like and looks like, and mindfully act in ways that cultivate it.
3. **Choose life:** avoid misoriented behavior.

When you practice these oriented steps, you give a gift to God and to others, and you give your True Self a drink from the overflow of God's house.³ The outcome, or effect, of pursuing orientation is predictable—over time, you will create a life that is more stable, more productive, and more secure.

The second level of karis is where the adventure really begins. You begin planting seeds with hope, but without attaching to expectations. At this level, you learn to:

1. **Love your neighbor as yourself:** treat very well those who support you.⁴
2. **Do good to the trustworthy community:** support members of the community who are investing in their true glory.
3. **Act with kindness toward the world:** offer gifts of care and support to those outside the trustworthy community.⁵

When we are healthier and more oriented, we are no longer driven by the fear of losing our Idol's life and can observe events without judgment. We mindfully acknowledge the Idol's efforts to control us, but we refuse to participate in the damage it causes. We remember what we really want: we want to enjoy more love and more life, and we want to be more capable of handling whatever life brings. When we make choices oriented toward achieving those desires, we become more trustworthy. We also learn more about God, which increases our trust, and we reveal that growing trust by courageously circulating our MATH—our money, abilities, time, and health. We circulate and then watch with anticipation to see what God will do. The outcome or effect of your circulation at this second level of karis is unpredictable; you cannot foresee what glorious things God will return to you. You just start drinking from the river of His delights, and in His light you see more and more light. You can never swallow too much of that river, and there is no end to what His light can reveal.

Circulation begins with letting go. We stop living an egocentric life and allow our resources to flow toward a real need or a real joy. We become someone's neighbor. Rather than waiting for others to give to us, we initiate the ecosystem of circulation. We develop the empathy required to know what another person needs or what would bring them joy. Offering joy is just as valuable as meeting a need. Before we have time to talk ourselves out of it, we let our resources flow to that person. We do something; when we see our chance, we act. By letting go of our resources, we let go of trying to save the life of our Idol—we let go of meeting the compulsive needs of our pride system, and we let go of trusting the Idol's dictates.⁶ Our life then becomes evidence of our trust in God and His trust in us. How does that work?

As we learn to trust God, we develop a magnanimous heart that responds to its own opportunities to circulate. Being magnanimous doesn't mean that we let go of all of our MATH all of the time. We still budget and prioritize, but we do not make our MATH another rigid legal system, so we can choose to stretch the comfort zone of our MATH to meet a need or a joy. This demonstrates our trust in God and gives Him the opportunity to demonstrate His trustworthiness toward us. Our choice shows God that we are trustworthy and willing to learn more trust.

This ongoing cycle of circulation with God allows resources to flow away from us, but it also allows resources to flow toward us. When we refuse to be motivated by greed and fear, our arms are open to give and receive. The resources of the Creation are then free to flow back and forth in a natural cycle. By allowing the tide to go out, we invite the tide's return. As we invest our MATH, we gain even more. Through entering into circulation, we experience an ever-increasing vitality that brings with it more and more joy.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, I am willing to let go and get into the flow. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

You might want to share an area of your life that has positively changed during this year of KF training.

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Every bit of guidance from the Bible, every call to love, and every declaration of your potential as a child of God is an invitation to respond with oriented action and trust. Your response is called faith. Faith is what it takes to fulfill the greatest commandment, which is to love God with all of our being and to love our neighbor as we would love ourselves.⁷

In the passage for this lesson, a lawyer asks Jesus which commandment is the greatest. Jesus responds with an answer that stirs up the lawyer’s self-hate because Jesus emphasizes action, not simply knowledge. The lawyer is proud of his scriptural knowledge, but Jesus challenges him to translate what he knows into action. The lawyer then feels anxious and tries to justify his inaction by asserting that the commandment is too vague for anyone to follow. He takes refuge in semantics by asking Jesus, “Who is my neighbor?”

Nancy wants to point out something in this passage that might surprise you. We are often taught that the neighbor is the one who was left for dead, the needy one. That is not what Jesus says. Jesus tells us that the neighbor is the one who has compassion and helps the one who has fallen into the hands of robbers. Neighbors take action on our behalf. The ones who take action on our behalf are the ones we are commanded to love as ourselves.

Let’s read **Luke 10:25–37** in Nancy’s translation. To help our understanding, Nancy has used the phrase *the one near* instead of the word *neighbor*.

²⁵And look, a certain expert in law stood up testing Jesus. He said, “Teacher, what shall I do to inherit eternal life?” ²⁶Jesus said to him, “What is written in the law? How do you read it?” ²⁷The lawyer replied, “You shall love the Lord your God out of the source of your desires, and from within your whole conscious self, your whole strength, and all of your intelligence; and you shall love the one near you as you would love yourself.” ²⁸Jesus said to him, “You have answered correctly. Do this, and you will live.” ²⁹But the expert in law, wishing to support his pride, said to Jesus, “And who is the one near me?”

³⁰Jesus replied, “A man was going down from Jerusalem to Jericho and he fell among thieves. They stripped off his clothes and beat him, wounding him, and then they disbanded, leaving him half-dead. ³¹By coincidence, a priest was going down the same road and saw the crime victim. Far from going near him, he went to the opposite side of the road to pass him by. ³²A Levite who was coming down to that place also saw the wounded man and, in just the same way, passed by on the other side in order to get as far away from him as possible.

³³A Samaritan who was on a journey came upon the victim and, seeing him, felt compassion. ³⁴And he came near to him, bandaged his traumas, pouring upon them soothing oil and healing wine. He lifted the man onto his own beast and, leading him to a

place to rest, took an interest in him. ³⁵On the next day he took out two denarii and gave them to the innkeeper (the one who receives everyone), and he said, ‘Take an interest in this man, and whatever more you spend, when I return, I myself will repay you.’

³⁶Now, in your opinion, which of these three people became the one near—or the neighbor—to him who was overwhelmed by thieves?” ³⁷The expert in law said, “The one who acted mercifully toward him.” Jesus said to the lawyer, “Go on your way, and you yourself do likewise.”

Take a deep breath.

Notice that the neighbor is not the religious leader or the person who claims special spiritual authority based on antecedents. Jesus teaches us that our neighbor is the one who comes near. The neighbor rescues and helps us when we have been set upon by robbers who have exploited and abused us for their own gain. We might look back on our lives and think to ourselves: “If it wasn’t for that person and their gifts to me, where would I be?” If you shudder at the thought of where you might be, then you have found your neighbor. Your neighbors are those who extend themselves and offer their own MATH on your behalf, not because you deserve it or because you made the first gesture, but because karis neighbors know how to love. They are the instrument of God’s love in your life. When your neighbor offers you a karis gift, God uses that gift to invite you into deeper karis relationship with Him. Their gift becomes God’s gift; He works through them to benefit you. So, when you respond to your neighbor with a gift of your own, you are responding to God.

When out of gratitude you offer something costly to your neighbor, you are saying to God: “I am ready to be in a growing relationship of trust—a relationship that requires courage for adventure, an ever-developing orientation, a commitment to reality, and new levels of endurance. I want a relationship that will help me step up to my design and purpose, and will train me to receive my inheritance. I am ready to declare the glory that is mine in Christ Jesus.” Your neighbors are those people who take action to support you in that marvelous process of becoming God’s trustworthy friend. How you respond to your neighbor declares to heaven your real intentions.

Offer gifts to those who have rescued and supported you, and then become a neighbor to others by taking the initiative to circulate with them. Follow the example of the Samaritan. Show mercy to someone who has been set upon by robbers in this misoriented and destructive culture. Become God’s karis gift and see what happens.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord Jesus, I am ready to become a neighbor. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe.
(Pause for 10 seconds)

Here is our integration focus: *Consider who might be your neighbor. What could it look like to love your neighbor as yourself? (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

Feelings

As you *consider what it might look like to love your neighbor as yourself*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush our feelings and thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Observe whatever tension you may be experiencing as you *consider what it might look like to love your neighbor as yourself*. *(Pause)* Feelings and fleeting thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider what it might look like to love your neighbor as yourself*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what hoarding or what curiosity feels like in your body. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider what it might look like to love your neighbor as yourself*. Do you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you judge loving your neighbor as yourself as good or, perhaps, as evil because it scares you? Like the lawyer, you may feel skeptical or defensive, or you may be full of excuses. *(Pause)* What do you believe about your neighbors, those who have supported and even rescued you? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created us to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you feel when they have *considered loving their neighbor as they love themselves*. You are not alone in your feelings. You are a human creature. *(Pause)* Feelings are just chemical reactions in your body bringing you information. With training, you can choose what you will do with that information. *(Pause)* When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. Breathe, and with compassion allow your body to process this experience with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

(Optional) Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are very grateful for this year of training together. Hold us in the power of this karis understanding and continue to guide us to our glory. As we co-labor with You, reveal the truth of who You created us to be with all of our potential in Christ. Help us to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with our community and the rest of the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

This is the last meeting in the Karis Fellowship training cycle. We hope to hear your voices next week as we welcome new members into our community and begin the cycle again. All current KF members who wish to join us, please register on the website.

¹ Psalm 36:8–10.

² www.youtube.com/watch?v=ihJAJA4ibEs.

³ Psalm 36:8.

⁴ Luke 10:27.

⁵ Galatians 6:10.

⁶ Luke 9:24.

⁷ Mark 12:28–34.